

Argumentative Essay



Argumentative essay...

- also known as
 - persuasive essays
 - opinion essays
 - position papers
 - the author adopts a position on a **debatable issue** and uses **reason and evidence** to convince the reader of his/her opinion.
- A good argumentative essay will use facts and evidence to support the argument, rather than just the author's thoughts and opinions.

CLASSICAL



- Present an existed idea
- Make your claim on it
- Provide the evidence to convince that your opinion is the right one.

TOULMIN



- Make a claim
- Provide the evidence
- Explain how it supports your claim
- Provide a rebuttal (opposing opinion) to show you've considered alternatives

ROGERIAN



- Discuss the opposing opinion and what it gets right
- Highlight the problem with this position
- Present your claim
- Suggest a compromise (what elements of your position could be beneficial for opponents)

- Classical: Topic (debatable issue), Claim (your opinion/your side), Supporting evidences (support reasons). What is missing: Counter argument/rebuttal.
- Toulmin: Claim/opinion on the topic, supporting reasons, rebuttal/counter claim+refutation (introductory paragraph, support reason 1, supporting reason 2, rebuttal/counter claim, concluding paragraph)
- Rogerian: Counter Claim/rebuttal + refutation, claim, supporting reasons (Introductory paragraph, counter-claim+refutation, supporting reason 1, supporting reason 2, conclusion)

Elements of a Convincing Argument

- **“Ethos”** Authoritative voice
 - What makes you a qualified writer on the topic?
 - Draw from expertise of other credible sources, or personal experience
 - Ex: “You know me - I've taught Sunday School at your church for years, babysat your children, and served as a playground director for many summers - so you know I can run your preschool.”
- **“Logos”** Appeal to reason,
 - Where logical statements come into play
 - reader is lead to agree as conclusions/implications follow reasonably from premises
 - Ex: “After years of disrespect from your boss, countless hours wasted, birthdays missed... it's time you took a stand.” More than a 100 peer-reviewed studies conducted over the past decade, and none suggest that this is an effective treatment for hair loss.”(can be experienced based, statistical and research based).
- **“Pathos”** Appeal to audience,
 - misunderstood as emotional appeal, but is finding common ground with the reader
 - appeal to ethical, humanist ideals, assuming the audience is a generally ethical crowd
 - Ex: “

Structure: Argumentative essay

- Introduction
 - provides some background information on topic
 - indicates that it is a controversial topic
 - ends with thesis statement
- Thesis Statement
 - one sentence at the end of the introduction before transitional hook
 - states your opinion on the issue, often using “should” or “must”
 - lists reasons to support that opinion
 - also mentions the counter argument (i.e. opposite opinion)
- Uses words like
 - Although; while; despite the fact that; However
- to distinguish it from your opinion.

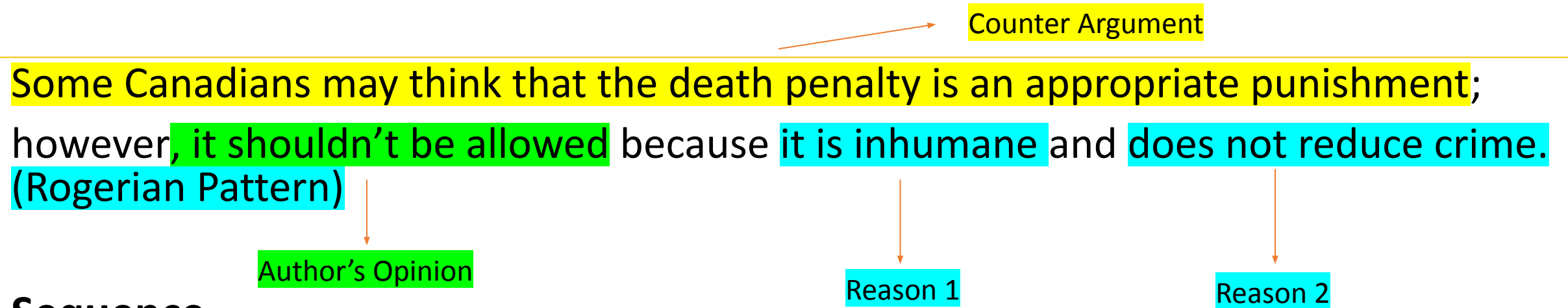
Argumentative Essay outline

1. Introduction paragraph
 - A. Hook
 - B. Background Information
 - C. Thesis Statement
 - D. **Transitional Hook**
2. Body paragraph 1
 - A. Present your first point and it's supporting evidence
 - B. Prove one of your opposition's claims to be false (argue the other side of the argument... why should people believe your side?)
3. Body paragraph 2
 - A. Present your second point and it's supporting evidence
 - B. Prove one of your opposition's claims to be false (argue the other side of the argument... why should people believe your side?)
4. Body paragraph 3
 - A. Present your third point and it's supporting evidence
 - B. Prove one of your opposition's claims to be false (argue the other side of the argument... why should people believe your side?)
5. Conclusion Paragraph
 - A. Restate thesis statement
 - B. Review 3 main points
 - C. Leave the reader with an interesting thought about your argument- remember: you want them to BELIEVE YOU!!!

Examples

Some Canadians (3rd person point of view) may think that the death penalty is an appropriate punishment (counter argument); however, (refutation word) it shouldn't be allowed (claim) because it is inhumane (reason 1) and does not reduce crime (reason 2).

Examples



Sequence

Counterargument – Author's Opinion – Reason 1 and Reason 2

Death penalty shouldn't be allowed(Author's Opinion) because it is inhumane (Reason 1) and does not reduce crime (Reason 2); however, some Canadians may think that the death penalty is an appropriate punishment. (counter Argument)(Toulmin Pattern)

Sequence

Author's Opinion-Reason 1 and Reason 2-Counter Argument

Examples

- Although the internet can spread misinformation, the internet is good for democracy
 - COUNTER ARGUMENT
 - because it lets us exercise freedom of speech and it exposes us to a variety of opinions.
- AUTHOR'S OPINION
- REASON 1
- REASON 2

Sequence

Counterargument – Author's Opinion – Reason 1 and Reason 2

- Body Paragraphs
- from your thesis discuss
- Counter Argument
 - briefly summarize it in a body paragraph, then disprove it using logic/evidence
 - using phrases like
 - Some people feel that ..., Many think that ..., Opponents say that ..., Some researchers argue that ...
- Reason 1 & Reason 2
 - begin with a topic sentence that reminds the reader of your opinion and introduces the reason that will be discussed in that paragraph
 - e.g. First, the internet is good for democracy because it lets citizens exercise their freedom of speech.
 - explain the logic of that reason, and provide examples, facts, and statistics
- Conclusion
 - restates your opinion
 - reviews the reasons and main evidence discussed in the body paragraphs

Claim/Thesis Statement

- A “claim” (also known as a “thesis statement” or “argument”) is the central idea of your paragraph or essay and should appear in the first sentence.
- Effective Claims are:
 - Assertive
 - Specific
 - Provable

Counterargument

The **counterargument** addresses the claims that oppose your audience. It may be located before or after your main claim.

- It demonstrates your credibility.
- recognizes concerns that your audience might have.
- For this reason, you must be both tactful and firm when presenting a counterargument.

Thesis Statement

- **Argument:** the main idea/topic that you are going to prove/claim
- **Main points:** what evidence will you use to prove your argument?
- **Counter-argument:** (opposition) an alternate theory/opinion contrary to your argument.
- **Structure:**
- **Although /Even though __ (Counter-argument) __, __ (Main point) __, and __ (Main point) __ suggest that __ (Argument/Claim).**
- Although cats can be stubborn, their self-sufficiency, and cleanliness prove that they make the best pets.
- core elements of the thesis:
- Argument: Cats (topic) are the best pets (claim).
- Evidence:
- Cats are self-sufficient.
- Cats are clean.
- Counter-Argument:
- Cats are stubborn.

Although cats can be stubborn (counter claim), they make the best pets (claim) because of their self-sufficiency and their cleanliness (reasons 1 and 2).

- AVOID GENERALIZATIONS, CLICHÉS, QUESTIONS, OR “STATING THE OBVIOUS”:
- Pollution is bad for the environment.
- Homelessness is a problem
- Should the Federal Reserve reduce the federal funds rate?
- The future looks bright for companies developing vaccines

background

Historians do not perform heart transplants, improve roads, or arrest criminals. In a society that expects education to serve useful purposes, the functions of history can seem more difficult to define. History is very useful in shaping our understanding of ourselves, other people and the wider community even though some believe this knowledge is outdated. → main points

argument

Tips for Writing a Good Argumentative Essay

- **#1: Make Your Thesis Clear**
 - Thesis is the key to the argumentative essay; if it isn't clear or readers can't find it easily, your entire essay will be weak. The typical spot for it is towards the last sentences of the introduction paragraph. Also make sure that your thesis makes clear what side of the argument you're on.
- **#2: Show Why the Other Side Is Weak**
 - Do not be tempted to ignore the other side of the argument and just focus on your side.
 - Before you begin writing, research what the other side believes, and what their strongest points are. In your essay, be sure to mention each of these and use evidence to explain why they're incorrect/weak arguments.
- **#3: Use Evidence to Support Your Side**
 - an essay can't be an argumentative essay if it doesn't support its argument with evidence. For every point you make, make sure you have facts to back it up. **Some examples are previous studies done on the topic, surveys of large groups of people, data points, etc.** This will make your essay much stronger than relying on your own opinions to support your argument.

Sample Introductory Paragraph

Anecdote

Lead-in

Thesis

Transitional hook

Sarah's phone went dead! the internet must have gone down usual in this small coastal town. With the approaching cyclone, she desperately needed updates, so she turned to a small box, grateful for some sound and updates. This experience highlights the importance of radio, especially in times of crisis, when other technologies fail. Although often considered outdated in the technical age (counterargument), radio programs remain a key communication medium (author's opinion) because they provide accessible news (reason 1) and deliver important emergency information (reason 2). Although radio is considered obsolete and devoid of tech by most people, it still offers an easy way to stay informed (**Refutation**).

Introduction		
Reader’s hook (anecdote/rhetorical question/ fact)	2	9
Lead-in to thesis (background information)	1	
Thesis Statement: counterargument, author’s argument, supporting evidence for author’s argument (Counterargument may be before or after author’s argument)	5	
Organization (body paragraphs)		
<u>First body paragraph</u> Has a topic sentence and presents counterargument, address the claims that oppose your audience, Transitional Hook	3	9
<u>Second body paragraph</u> Has a topic sentence and presents the strongest supporting argument/proposition, with 3 supporting evidences. Transitional Hook	3	
<u>Third body paragraph</u> Has a topic sentence and presents the second strongest supporting argument/proposition, with 3 supporting evidences. Transitional Hook	3	
Conclusion		
Thesis is restated- key points summarized-Includes a concluding remark/statement	2+1	3
Cohesion		
Transitional words are used to connect paragraphs & to connect ideas within paragraphs to create cohesion and logical flow of ideas.	1+1	2
Mechanics		
free of distracting spelling, punctuation, and grammatical errors; varied sentence structure is used throughout	2	2
Total marks		25

Assignment 2

- Students will work in groups of five to prepare and deliver a presentation in Week 10 and 11 on an argumentative topic, following the argumentative essay structure demonstrated in the sample essay (introduction with thesis, counterargument, supporting reasons with evidence, and conclusion).